based in Wilderness, while Oupa Jan and the De Villiers clan owned a holiday home in the Strand, near Cape Town.

Those were great days.

In Wilderness, we used to pitch a tent in the garden and play endless games of cricket on the beach – one year Gerrit Deist, 'the finest bowler I ever faced', came along and raised the standard of play. In the Strand, we would sit and listen in awesome admiration as Oupa Jan played 'Silent Night' on the harmonica.

'Shhhhh,' my mother would say.

Ah, yes, my mother, Millie de Villiers … a force of nature, selfless, loving, as well as my tennis coach.